

THE LONG ROAD

A journey game where **every turn is a choice before it is a question**. Your class picks the road — easy, steady, or the hard pass that pays — and what they get wrong blocks the road until they come back and fix it.

12

tasks, each ending in something
playable

1

finished game included

0

ways to lose in front of the
class

Built on what the research actually says about motivation.

Competence is the strongest driver of student motivation — stronger than autonomy, stronger than belonging — and points do not produce it. So the loudest moment in this game is not a high score. **It is the moment a student fixes something they got wrong.**

No coding background. About two hours.

One HTML file. Nothing installed, no accounts for anybody, no subscription, and it runs with the wifi down. Your content goes in one list at the top.

Inside

Twelve tasks with the exact prompts written out in full · the finished game, playable today · why this shape beats a quiz with a health bar · how to write questions and the one-line reasons that do the teaching · five ways to run it · and building in a famous genre without stealing from it.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

The twelve tasks at a glance

Every task ends with something on screen you can play. If it does not, stop and fix it before moving on.

#	Task	Ends with
1	Decide the journey and the ideas	A destination and your content, tagged
2	The country, and the loop	A landscape that scrolls
3	Things that sit on the ground	Hills with trees actually on them
4	The fork — choice before question	Three roads you choose between
5	The question the road asks	A road that resolves
6	Supplies, and what a wrong answer costs	Stakes without a loss screen
7	The one line that teaches	A reason shown after every miss
8	Missed ideas block the road	A washed-out crossing on your map
9	Fixing one opens it, loudly	The best moment in the game
10	Camps, and gear worth choosing	A second layer of decisions
11	Arrival, scored without ranking	An ending everybody reaches
12	Everyone can play it	Keyboard, touch, Chromebook

Stop anywhere after task 6

Tasks 1 to 6 give you a real journey game. **Tasks 8 and 9 are the ones that make it teach**, and they are the reason this pack exists.

Why not a quiz with a health bar

The obvious classroom game is a quiz with points bolted on. It is obvious because it is easy, and it is weaker than it looks.

What a quiz with points actually does

The student has exactly one input: pick the right answer. There is no plan, no trade, no reason to think past the next box. Two students playing the same set have the same experience. **And bolting a score on top can reduce interest rather than raise it** — the reward becomes the point, and the content becomes the toll you pay for it.

What a choice does instead

Put a decision *before* the question and everything changes. Now the student is weighing: do I take the hard pass because we need the supplies, or the low trail because we are running thin? **The thinking happens before they have even seen the question**, and it continues after, because the outcome changes what they choose next.

And the difficulty solves itself

In this game the **player chooses the difficulty by choosing the road**. No hidden algorithm, no labeling anybody. The student who wants the hard pass takes it; the one who needs a gentler run takes the low trail; both are playing the same game at the same table and neither has been told which one they are.

The test to apply to any game you build: if two students with the same content would see the same sequence of screens, **there is no choice in your game** and you have built a worksheet that beeps.

The loudest moment belongs to the student who was wrong

If you take one thing from this pack into your teaching and never build a game at all, take this.

What the research says, in one line

Of the three things that drive motivation — feeling capable, having a say, and belonging — **feeling capable is the strongest**. And the evidence on gamified classrooms is blunt about the rest: points and badges lift interest and enjoyment but do **almost nothing for how capable a student feels**.

So the game celebrates the right thing

A score says *you were already good*. That is news to nobody, least of all the student who was not.

Fixing something you got wrong says: you are better than you were twenty minutes ago. That is competence, it is visible, and it is the one thing a worksheet can never show a child.

How it is built, mechanically

Every question is tagged with an **idea**. Miss it, and that idea **blocks a road** on your map — you can see it, you can go around it, and it is waiting. Come back and answer it right and the crossing opens permanently, with the biggest celebration in the game. **The map itself changes shape because the student learned something**.

This is also just good teaching

Bringing a missed idea back later rather than immediately is spacing, and it is one of the best-evidenced things in learning science. You are not decorating a quiz. You are building the thing the research says works, and making it visible.

WHAT YOU NEED

Before task 1

An AI chat you are signed in to

Any of them. You paste prompts and read what comes back. You are at the keyboard throughout.

Twelve to twenty questions, across three or four ideas

More than the boss-battle sort of game needs, because this one sorts by idea and by difficulty. **You need some easy, some middling and some genuinely hard** — the hard road has to actually be hard or the choice is fake.

A browser and a folder

One HTML file you double-click. That is the whole deployment.

What you do not need

Node, npm, a terminal, an account, a server, an art program or any audio files. The art is text, the sound is generated, and the whole thing is one file.

Two hours, not ninety minutes. This is a bigger build than a quiz game and the pack says so up front. If you have twenty minutes tonight, do tasks 1 to 4 — a fork in the road with three real options is the moment this stops being a worksheet.

TASK 1

Decide the journey, and tag your ideas

Ten minutes with a pen. The only task the AI cannot do, and the one that decides whether the rest works.

Three decisions

Where are they going? Any destination worth reaching. Fort Verity. The Summit. The Last Library. It does not have to relate to your content — the journey is the frame, your questions are the country.

What are the three or four ideas? Not topics — ideas. "Evaporation", "condensation", "runoff". The game tracks mastery by idea, so this list is the spine of everything.

How long is the road? Twelve legs is about twenty-five minutes with a class discussing each fork.

Write the questions in this shape now

```
{ q:'A puddle disappears on a hot day. Which process did the most work?',  
  a:['Condensation','Evaporation','Precipitation','Runoff'], ok:1,  
  idea:'evaporation',  
  level:2,  
  why:'The water did not go anywhere solid or liquid. Heat turned it to vapor.' }
```

Five fields, and the last two are the ones that matter. idea is what the game tracks and blocks roads with. why is the only teaching the game does.

You need real hard ones

Level 3 questions are what the hard pass asks. If your hardest question is still recall of a definition, **the choice between roads is a lie** and students will work that out in four minutes. A level 3 should apply the idea to a situation they have not seen: a town paves a wetland, a forest is cleared, two puddles in different light.

Task 1 ends when

You have a destination and twelve or more questions, each tagged with an idea, a level and a one-line reason.

TASK 2

The country, and the loop

A landscape that moves, and proof the game is alive.

PROMPT 1 · THE WORLD

Build a single HTML file, no frameworks and no build step, that runs by opening it in a browser. Put a canvas in it, 640 by 360, scaled to fit, with `imageSmoothingEnabled false`. Set up a **state object**, a **draw function** and a **game loop using requestAnimationFrame**, kept separate. Draw a sky that fades from dark at the top to lighter at the horizon, then **three layers of rolling hills drawn with a sine wave**, each scrolling at a different speed. Add a low sun and a few birds. **Give me one palette of sixteen colors as named constants at the top and use nothing outside it.**

The sixteen-color rule is not decoration

A **sprite with forty colors turns to noise at thirty pixels tall**, because the eye cannot separate adjacent shades at that size. Fewer colors read better, always. Ask for the palette as named constants and every later change is one edit in one place.

Three speeds, not one

Far hills drift slowly, near hills move fast. That difference is what makes a flat picture look like distance, and it costs one number per layer.

Task 2 ends when

You have a landscape that scrolls, with the far hills lagging the near ones.

TASK 3

Things that sit on the ground

The single fix that separates a real scene from a pasted one.

PROMPT 2 · SPRITES ON THE LAND

Add pixel sprites **written as arrays of text**, one character per pixel, a dot for transparent, so I can edit art by typing. Make a traveler, a tree, a mountain peak, a tent and a flag. Then — this is the important part — **write a function that asks a hill what its surface height is at a given x, and place trees and peaks so they sit exactly on that line** rather than at a fixed height. Give the traveler a small bob. **Light everything from the top left**: a darker row along the bottom of each sprite.

The mistake this prompt exists to prevent

Left alone, a model draws hills and then draws trees at a fixed y. **The trees float over the hills or sink into them** and the scene reads as flat and wrong without anybody being able to say why. Asking the hill where its surface is, and standing things on it, is four lines and it is most of the difference.

The silhouette test, before you go further

Fill each sprite with solid black. **Can you still tell what it is?** If not, redraw it. If a shape does not read in silhouette it will not read on a projector from the back row, and the back row is your hardest audience.

Task 3 ends when

Trees stand on hills, the traveler breathes, and nothing floats.

The fork: choice before question

This is the task that makes it a game rather than a quiz. Everything else is scenery around it.

PROMPT 3 · THE FORK

Below the canvas, before any question is asked, **offer two or three roads as buttons**. Each shows a name, a short description, and what it asks and pays. Build three kinds: **an easy road** that asks two level-1 questions, is slow and costs no supplies; **a steady road** that asks one level-2 question; and **a hard road** that asks one level-3 question, gains a day and pays a supply. **Generate the set fresh at every fork and shuffle the order**, so no two journeys are the same. Number the buttons 1 to 3 and let those keys choose.

Why the choice has to come first

If the question comes first and the choice is how to spend a reward, you have a quiz with a shop. **The choice has to be made in ignorance of the question** — that is what turns it into a judgment about risk, and judgment under uncertainty is where the thinking lives.

The trade has to be real

If the hard road is strictly better, everyone takes it and there is no decision. **Each road must be right in some situations and wrong in others**: the hard pass pays when you are healthy and punishes when you are thin. That is the whole design.

Task 4 ends when

You reload twice and get different forks, and you can honestly say you had to think about which one to take.

TASK 5

The question the road asks

Now the content arrives, and the road decides which question you get.

PROMPT 4 · DRAWING THE QUESTION

Put my questions in a **plain array at the very top of the file**, above all game code, with a comment saying this is the part a teacher edits. Each has a question, four answers, which is right counting from zero, an **idea**, a **level** from 1 to 3, and a **why**. When a road is chosen, draw a question **matching that road's level**. Two rules on the draw: **never ask the same idea twice in a row**, and **prefer questions the player has seen least**. Show it as real HTML buttons below the canvas, not drawn on the canvas, numbered 1 to 4, and shuffle the answer order every time.

Never twice in a row is not fussiness

Asking three questions about evaporation back to back teaches a student to answer without reading, because the pattern is doing the work. **Mixing ideas forces them to work out which idea applies**, which is the skill that transfers out of your classroom and into a test.

Buttons in HTML, not painted on canvas

Canvas text cannot be reached with Tab or read aloud by a screen reader. Use the canvas for the world and the page for the interface. That is the right call, not a compromise.

Task 5 ends when

The hard road actually asks you a hard question and the easy road does not.

TASK 6

Supplies, and what a wrong answer costs

Stakes, without anybody losing in front of the room.

PROMPT 5 · SUPPLIES

Add supplies, starting at six, shown as icons in a status bar along with the day count and progress toward the destination. A wrong answer **costs one supply**. A clean hard road **pays one back**. **When supplies reach zero the player does not lose** — they fall back to the last camp, lose three days, get half their supplies back, and continue. **There is no lose screen anywhere in this game.**

Read that last line again, because it is the point

A shared score that can be lost means one student's wrong answer visibly costs everybody, and the room always knows whose it was. For a student who is already struggling, **that produces exactly the feeling of not being good enough that you are trying to fight**.

So: no losing. Everybody arrives. **Arrival is scored, not passed or failed** — days taken, supplies left, ideas locked in. A class can want a better run without anyone having been the reason.

What replaces the tension you gave up

Scarcity. Running low on supplies changes which road you dare take, and that is a better tension than a fail screen because **it makes them think rather than makes them anxious**.

Task 6 ends when

You deliberately run yourself out of supplies and the game keeps going.

TASK 7

The one line that teaches

The only teaching this game does, and it costs one field per question.

PROMPT 6 · THE REASON

On a wrong answer: mark the clicked one red, **highlight the right one in green**, and show the question's **why** underneath in a boxed line. **Hold all of that on screen for about 2.6 seconds before moving on, against 1 second after a right answer.** Do not use color alone to show which was right — the correct answer also gets a label a screen reader would announce.

The long pause is deliberate and it is the whole feature

After a right answer the class already knows, so move on. After a wrong one the right answer is on screen and **every eye in the room is on it**. That extra second and a half is the reteaching. Ask for it by name, because no model will think of it.

Why, not what

Weak: "The answer is evaporation."

Strong: "The water did not go anywhere solid or liquid. Heat turned it to vapor." A student who reads that learns the idea. A student who reads the first one learns which button to press.

Write the reason for the student who got it wrong

Not a definition. The sentence that fixes the specific confusion that made them choose the wrong one. You already know what that confusion is — you have graded it a hundred times.

Task 7 ends when

You answer wrong on purpose and find yourself reading the reason before it disappears.

Missed ideas block the road

The mechanic that turns a game into a review that actually reviews.

PROMPT 7 · BLOCKED CROSSINGS

Track which **ideas** the player has got wrong in a list. Once there is at least one, a **washed-out crossing can appear as one of the roads at a fork**, tagged so it is obviously different, saying "you turned back here before". It asks a question **about that specific idea**. Show a count of blocked roads in the status bar. **The crossing is always optional** — there is always another road at the same fork.

Why it must be optional

Forcing a student back to the thing they just failed is a punishment, and it reads as one. **Letting them see it, go around it, and come back when they are ready** is the same content with the opposite feeling — and going back is now their decision, which is exactly the autonomy the whole design is built on.

And it is spacing, which is the real reason it works

Bringing a missed idea back **later** rather than immediately is one of the best-evidenced things in learning science. Immediately is recognition. Later is retrieval, and retrieval is what lasts. **The game is not decorating good practice; it is enforcing it.**

What a student sees

A map with a broken bridge on it that has their mistake standing on the other side. That is a far better way to say "you do not have this yet" than a red X, and nobody else in the room can see whose it is.

Task 8 ends when

You miss one on purpose and a washed-out crossing turns up a few forks later with that idea waiting on it.

Fixing one opens the road, loudly

The most important twenty lines in this pack.

PROMPT 8 · THE FIX

When the player answers a washed-out crossing correctly: **remove that idea from the missed list, add it to mastered, and show a full-screen celebration** — the only one in the game. It says the road is open, names the idea, and says they turned back here before. Give it the longest sound in the game. **Also**, when they fix a missed idea anywhere else, make that loud too: a big floating "FIXED", the same sound, and a line saying they have just put right what they got wrong. **Nothing else in this game gets a full screen. Not arriving, not a good run, nothing.**

Why this and nothing else

Because **what a game celebrates is what it teaches students to value**. Celebrate speed and they rush. Celebrate a score and they learn that being good at it already is the thing. **Celebrate a fix and you have told every child in the room that getting better is the point** — and the ones who needed to hear that are the ones who got it wrong first.

The measure the game reports

Not a score. **"Ideas locked in", which only ever goes up**, and at the end, how many of them were put right after getting them wrong. That second number is the one worth reading out.

What not to add, however tempting

No leaderboard with names. No visible per-student score. Nothing that lets the room work out who cost them what. **Public ranking harms the students you built this for**, and it is the easiest thing in the world to add by accident.

Task 9 ends when

You miss one on purpose, go back, fix it, and the celebration feels slightly bigger than you expected. That is correct.

TASK 10

Camps, and gear worth choosing

A second layer of decisions, and a moment to breathe.

PROMPT 9 · CAMPS

Every four legs, stop at a camp. **No question.** Offer three pieces of gear from a set of five and let the player take one. Each must be **a real trade rather than a straight bonus**: a lantern that shows what a road will ask before choosing it, a mule that carries two more supplies, an old map that adds a fourth road at every fork, a charm that makes the first wrong answer on each road free, a rope that softens the hard roads. Never offer one they already have.

Why a stop with no question in it

Pacing. Twelve questions in a row is a test whatever you draw around it. A camp every four legs gives the room somewhere to argue about strategy instead of content, and **that argument is the moment the quiet students join in.**

Gear that changes how you play, not how well you score

The lantern does not make questions easier — it makes the *choice* better informed. That is the right kind of power, because it rewards thinking about the game rather than just knowing more.

Task 10 ends when

You take a lantern on one run and a mule on the next and the two runs genuinely play differently.

TASK 11

Arrival, scored without ranking

Everybody gets there. What differs is how.

PROMPT 10 · ARRIVING

When the last leg is done, show an arrival screen with **days taken, ideas locked in, how many of those were fixed after getting them wrong, and supplies left**. Save the best run to localStorage — ranked by **ideas first and days second**, never by speed alone — and show it on the title screen. Wrap storage in try and catch. Add a button to travel again, with everything reshuffled.

Ideas first, days second, and never speed alone

Whatever the record measures is what the class will optimise. Rank on speed and they will guess fast on the easy road. **Rank on ideas and the best strategy is learning the content**, which is the only alignment that matters in a classroom game.

What the class record is, and is not

One line, no names on it: "23 ideas in 14 days." Third period can try to beat second period without any individual child being the reason. That is belonging without ranking, and it is the version that works in a mixed room.

Task 11 ends when

You arrive twice, and the second run feels different from the first because you chose differently.

TASK 12

Everyone can play it

The last task, and the one that decides whether it works in your actual room.

PROMPT 11 · REACH

Make this work for somebody using a **keyboard instead of a mouse**: every road and every answer reachable with Tab, usable with Enter, number keys 1 to 4 working for both, a clearly visible outline on the focused one, and focus moved to the first option whenever new choices appear. **Never use color alone** to carry meaning. Buttons big enough for a finger, one column on a narrow screen, and it must fit a Chromebook with nothing cut off.

Move the focus, or the keyboard run breaks

When a new fork appears, focus has to land on the first road by itself. Without that, a keyboard player has to Tab from the top of the page every single turn, and they will give up long before they tell you.

The Chromebook test is the real test

You built it on a laptop and your class has a cart. Open it on the actual hardware, at the actual resolution, before the actual lesson. Two minutes now or a ruined period later.

Task 12 ends when

You play a whole journey with your hands on the number keys, on the machine your class will use.

The six failures you will actually hit

In roughly the order they arrive.

What you see	What it is, and the sentence that fixes it
Trees floating over the hills	Sprites at a fixed height. Say: ask the hill function for its surface height at that x and stand the sprite on it.
The old question still showing under the new fork	A panel never hidden. Say: hide the question panel whenever the fork appears.
Every road feels the same	The levels are not really different. This is a content problem, not a code one — go back and make the level 3 questions genuinely hard.
Blocked crossings never appear	Misses are being recorded against the question, not the idea. Say: track missed ideas, not missed questions.
It wants me to run npm install	You got a framework. Say: rewrite as one HTML file, no frameworks, no libraries, no build step.
It worked and now the third change broke it	The file has outgrown the chat. Fresh chat, paste the whole file, ask for one change, ask for the whole file back.

The habit worth more than the table: paste the error *with what you were doing*. "It broke" gets guesses. "I clicked the hard road and the screen froze, here is the console" gets the fix.

Every prompt, in one place – 1 to 4

Copy and paste. Square brackets mean put your own words in.

1 • THE WORLD

Build a single HTML file, no frameworks and no build step, that runs by opening it in a browser. Canvas 640 by 360, scaled to fit, imageSmoothingEnabled false. A state object, a draw function and a game loop using requestAnimationFrame, kept separate. A sky fading dark to light, three layers of rolling hills from a sine wave each scrolling at a different speed, a low sun and a few birds. Give me one palette of sixteen colors as named constants at the top and use nothing outside it.

2 • SPRITES ON THE LAND

Add pixel sprites written as arrays of text, one character per pixel, a dot for transparent. A traveler, a tree, a peak, a tent, a flag. Write a function that asks a hill what its surface height is at a given x, and place trees and peaks so they sit exactly on that line rather than at a fixed height. Give the traveler a small bob. Light everything from the top left with a darker row along the bottom of each sprite.

3 • THE FORK

Below the canvas, before any question is asked, offer two or three roads as buttons, each with a name, a short description and what it asks and pays. An easy road asking two level-1 questions, slow, costing no supplies. A steady road asking one level-2. A hard road asking one level-3 that gains a day and pays a supply. Generate the set fresh at every fork and shuffle the order. Number the buttons and let those keys choose.

4 • DRAWING THE QUESTION

Put my questions in a plain array at the very top of the file, above all game code, with a comment saying this is the part a teacher edits. Each has a question, four answers, which is right counting from zero, an idea, a level from 1 to 3, and a why. When a road is chosen, draw a question matching that level. Never ask the same idea twice running, and prefer questions seen least. Real HTML buttons below the canvas, numbered, answers shuffled.

Every prompt, in one place – 5 to 8

5 • SUPPLIES

Add supplies starting at six, shown as icons in a status bar with the day count and progress to the destination. A wrong answer costs one. A clean hard road pays one back. When supplies reach zero the player does not lose: they fall back to the last camp, lose three days, get half their supplies back and continue. There is no lose screen anywhere in this game.

6 • THE REASON

On a wrong answer mark the clicked one red, highlight the right one green, and show the question's why underneath in a boxed line. Hold all of it for about 2.6 seconds before moving on, against 1 second after a right answer. Never use color alone: the right answer also gets a label a screen reader announces.

7 • BLOCKED CROSSINGS

Track which ideas the player has got wrong. Once there is at least one, a washed-out crossing can appear as one of the roads at a fork, tagged so it is obviously different, saying they turned back here before, asking a question about that specific idea. Show a count of blocked roads in the status bar. The crossing is always optional and there is always another road at the same fork.

8 • THE FIX

When a washed-out crossing is answered right, remove that idea from missed, add it to mastered, and show a full-screen celebration, the only one in the game, naming the idea and saying they turned back here before. Give it the longest sound. Also make fixing a missed idea anywhere else loud: a big floating FIXED, the same sound, a line saying they have put right what they got wrong. Nothing else gets a full screen, including arriving.

PROMPTS

Every prompt, in one place – 9 to 12

9 • CAMPS

Every four legs, stop at a camp with no question. Offer three pieces of gear from a set of five and let the player take one. Each is a real trade, not a bonus: a lantern showing what a road will ask, a mule carrying two more supplies, an old map adding a fourth road at every fork, a charm making the first wrong answer on each road free, a rope softening the hard roads. Never repeat one.

10 • ARRIVING

At the end of the last leg show days taken, ideas locked in, how many were fixed after being missed, and supplies left. Save the best run to localStorage ranked by ideas first and days second, never speed alone, and show it on the title screen. Wrap storage in try and catch. A button to travel again with everything reshuffled.

11 • REACH

Make this work for somebody using a keyboard instead of a mouse: every road and answer reachable with Tab, usable with Enter, number keys working for both, a visible outline on the focused one, and focus moved to the first option whenever new choices appear. Never use color alone. Buttons big enough for a finger, one column on a narrow screen, fitting a Chromebook with nothing cut off.

12 • WHEN THREE ROUNDS HAVE NOT FIXED IT

[Start a fresh chat.] Here is my whole file. [paste it] Change only this one thing: [the thing]. Do not change anything else, and give me the whole file back.

What is in this download

long-road.html

The finished game, built by exactly these twelve tasks and played through before publication — a full journey answering everything right, another answering everything wrong, and a run that misses on purpose then goes back and clears the crossing. **Open it and play it first.** Knowing what the target feels like makes every prompt land better.

Two ways to use this pack

Build it — work the twelve tasks and end up with something you understand well enough to change in March. **Play it** — swap the questions at the top and use it this week, then read the tasks when you want to change something.

The part you edit

```
const DESTINATION = 'Fort Verity';
const QUESTIONS = [
  { q: '...', a: ['...', '...', '...', '...'], ok: 0,
    idea: 'evaporation', level: 2,
    why: 'One line saying why that is right.' },
];
```

Everything below that is the game and you never have to touch it.

Twelve questions is the floor, twenty is comfortable. The game sorts by idea and by level, so a thin bank means the hard road runs out of hard questions and starts feeling like the easy one.

Writing the content this game needs

This game asks more of your questions than a quiz game does, and it pays you back for it.

Three levels, and they have to be really different

Level 1 — do you know the word? "Water turning to vapor is called what?"

Level 2 — can you spot it happening? "A puddle disappears on a hot day. Which process did the most work?"

Level 3 — can you use it somewhere new? "A town paves over a wetland. What most likely happens downstream?" **If your level 3 is still a definition, the hard road is a lie.**

Wrong answers are the mistakes your students actually make

Weak: Evaporation / A dog / Tuesday / Purple.

Strong: Evaporation / Condensation / Precipitation / Transpiration. Every one is real, so getting it right means knowing the difference rather than spotting the joke. **Your last quiz already has the four best wrong answers on it.**

The reason line is the part people skip

It is the only teaching in the whole game. Write it for the student who picked the wrong one, not for the one who already knew. One sentence, plain, aimed at the confusion rather than at the definition.

Ask an AI for help the right way

"Here are four of my questions with the wrong answers my students actually give. Write four more at level 3 — applying the idea to a situation they have not seen — each with a one-line reason aimed at the misconception." Never send student work or names; type the misconceptions in yourself.

Five ways to run it

1. Whole class, one screen, a vote at every fork

Start here. The vote is the whole point: the argument about which road to take is students reasoning about their own confidence out loud, and it costs you nothing to run.

2. Two teams, alternating forks

Each team chooses on its turn. Same journey, two strategies, and the comparison at the end is about decisions rather than about who is smarter.

3. Individually on Chromebooks

Everyone gets their own road and their own blocked crossings. This is the version where the game is quietly differentiating and nobody in the room can tell.

4. A station for early finishers

Leave it open. The class record is on the title screen and it only counts ideas.

5. A substitute can run it

"Open this file, project it, let them vote." Nothing to log into, nothing to break, and no way for it to go wrong while you are out.

The two minutes that make it land: at the end, ask the class which fork they would take differently, and why. That is a conversation about their own understanding, and the game just gave them the vocabulary for it.

Building in somebody else's genre without stealing

A journey with forks, supplies and a destination is a very old shape, and some famous games use it. Here is where the line sits.

The distinction that matters

Systems are not protected. Expression is. Branching routes, resources, random encounters, a map, upgrade stops — those are rules, used by hundreds of games. **Names, characters, artwork, music, logos and written lines are protected**, and those are what you must not take.

So you may freely

Build a journey toward a destination · offer branching routes with different risk · track a resource that runs down · stop at camps for upgrades · end with a scored arrival · use a chunky limited-palette look, which is a hardware idiom hundreds of independent games use.

And you must never

Use a protected game's title, characters, place names, item names or written lines — anywhere, including in your code and your file names · copy, trace or recolor its artwork or fonts · use its music · reuse its famous lines, including the short ones everybody can quote. **Write your own, in your own voice.**

The checklist, at the end of every session

Search the whole file for the protected names, and expect none · read every line a player sees out loud and rewrite any that sounds borrowed · look at each sprite and ask whether a fan would name it · hum your own victory sound and make sure it is not somebody else's tune.

And the practical point. A game you keep in your classroom is a very different risk from one you publish or sell. In your room this is mostly about modelling it properly for students. **This is not legal advice — it is the line a careful teacher can hold.**

The shortest privacy page in this series

The honest answer is that there is almost nothing to say, and that is the point.

What this game knows about your students

Nothing. No names, no accounts, no scores against people. There is nowhere to type a name and nothing to type it into.

What leaves the room

Nothing. No server, no network call, no analytics, no company behind it. Unplug the internet and it plays the same.

The one thing it saves

A best run — ideas and days — in that browser on that machine, with no name attached by design. Clear browsing data and it is gone, and nothing that matters is lost.

The feature to refuse

Sooner or later you will want to store who got the best run. Do not. That one change turns a game with no data into a student record on a shared classroom computer. **A record with nobody's name on it is still something a class will fight over**, and it is the version that cannot hurt anybody.

For an administrator, in one sentence: "It is a file on my computer with no student information in it that does not connect to anything." True, and the whole disclosure.

Eight things to try before a class sees it

Try this	You want
Reload twice and compare the first fork	Different roads on offer
Take the hard road three times	Genuinely harder questions
Answer everything wrong on purpose	You fall back, you never lose
Miss one, then go back to its crossing	A full-screen moment when you fix it
Play a run taking only easy roads	A slower arrival, not a punishment
Reach a camp twice	Different gear offered
Play the whole thing on number keys	Never needing the mouse
Open it on the classroom machine	Nothing cut off, sound audible

The one that catches the most

Missing on purpose and going back. It is the mechanic the whole design rests on, it is the one most likely to be silently broken, and it is the last thing anybody thinks to test.

And one worth doing with a person

Hand it to a colleague and say nothing. Watch which road they take first. If they pick at random rather than reading, your road descriptions are not doing their job.

How this pack is built, and what it does not claim

Why this shape, and not a quiz with a health bar

The first version of this product *was* a quiz with a health bar, and it was not good enough. The rebuild is built on three findings: **feeling capable is the strongest driver of motivation**, ahead of autonomy and belonging; **points and badges lift enjoyment but do almost nothing for feeling capable**; and **public ranking actively harms students who are already struggling**. Everything in the design follows from those three.

What was tested before this went out

The included game was played in a real browser three ways: a full journey answering everything correctly, a full journey answering everything wrong, and a run that missed on purpose then returned to clear the crossing. The wrong-answer run **fell back and continued rather than ending**, blocked crossings appeared and tracked the right ideas, the fix fired its full-screen moment and moved the idea from missed to mastered, and camps offered gear. No console errors in any run.

What is NOT claimed

- **Not a replacement for Blooket or Gimkit**, and not a replacement for the AI game generators either. Those start faster and look more finished. What this is instead: yours, with no logins, working offline, and changeable.
- **Not a gradebook**. It records nothing about any student and should not.
- **Not research of my own**. The findings above are other people's, summarized honestly; this pack applies them, it does not test them.
- **Not going to come out identical**. You are working with a model. Your country will look different from mine, and that is the point.

Why the prompts spend so long saying no

No frameworks. No color-only signals. No lose screen. No leaderboard with names. Left alone a model builds the most common version of a thing, and the most common classroom game is a quiz with points on it. **Saying no is the part of prompting nobody teaches, and it is most of the skill.**

If this was useful

Leaving a review earns you TPT credit

TPT gives you credit toward future purchases for every review you leave, and reviews are how other teachers find work like this. Thirty seconds.

If it did not work, tell me before you rate it

The Q&A on the listing reaches me directly. A game that will not open is almost always one line, and I would far rather fix it than leave you with a file that does nothing.

The one thing to take away

What a game celebrates is what it teaches students to value. Celebrate a score and you have told them that being good at it already is the point. Celebrate a fix and you have told them that getting better is. **That is true of your classroom whether or not you ever build a game.**

Built and audited by two certified teachers.

Every prompt here was run. The game was played to the destination three different ways, including the one where you get everything wrong, before this went out.